

*The stolen hour is yours and the enemy's nest is behind you. Now a brother's name is put into your hands, and a thing he left half-finished — work for one of the Order's own, and no one else.*

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*They send you down the Broad Street, where the great houses crowd the carnival, and you keep your heads down and your ears open the way couriers learn to. What you catch on the way does not sit easy. Two drapers on a step: that the komtur himself sued for terms with the townsmen weeks ago — wrote to Marienburg for leave to treat with them — and the Grand Master forbade it; that even he can see which way this falls. A pedlar, lower: that the bishops are turning their faces away now, the Pomesanian one having sheltered the towns' own meetings in years past. An old waterman, plainly, as you pass: that the Order keeps salt and copper and amber in its fist and lets no man trade but through the brothers' hand. None of them know whose letters you carry tonight. You are not certain, just now, that you would want them to.*

*The house they bring you to is old — older than the quarrel — and its front is painted: a band of beasts under the eaves, faded to earth and moss and ox-blood, the kind of work no townsman troubles to read any more. Most walk past it as you would pass a wall. But a brother of the Order did not pass it. Dead now, like the other one — they keep dying, your brothers, in twos and threes behind that wall — and what he left was folded into the leaf they put in your hand: eight beasts drawn close and careful, and beneath them, a line meant for one of his own.*

Brother — what is ours, we have always set where only our own would think to look. There is an old house on the Broad Street with the beasts of our craft painted on its front, among a deal of common work; and of the eight I have copied here, only some were ever truly set on that wall by our hand. A townsman sees only old paint. But you are of our own, and our own know their own beasts. Go, and read the wall as I taught it. Mark which of these eight stand upon it in truth — no more, no fewer — and bring their names back. By that, and that alone, will you be known.

*The brother's certainty is a warm thing to stand in — surer than the cold talk in the streets, and you let it warm you, and try not to weigh which of the two is telling you the truth. You serve the Order's cause tonight; or so the letter in your bag says. The bishops turn away, the master will not treat, the brothers thin to a handful behind their wall — and still here is a small faith asked of you, that you are one of the few who can read what the rest walk past. So you stand before the painted beasts in the carnival dark, the leaf in your hand, and match them one by one: which of the eight the old wall truly bears, and which were never there at all. Set down their letters. Only our own will tell them apart. Only our own will pass.*

↪ GAME MASTER — Bring the letters of the beasts you found on the wall to the Game Master, who keeps to the Rynek Staromiejski (the Old Town market square). If you have read it as one of the Order's own would, what the brother kept will be given to you in return — and with it, your next orders.